

Early attempts

This was not the first time that India had extended support to foreign parties. In the 19th century, Indian labourers built a line in Abyssinia (part of present-day Ethiopia). Even without being an active participant in the two world wars, India made significant contributions in terms of men and materiel. However, these were channelized under the British. The context, mechanisms, and motivations were far different when India assisted other newly independent nations in building their railways. There was little vested interest and the idea was, as author RR Bhandari wrote in *Indian Railways: Glorious 150 Years*, “promoting technical cooperation amongst developing countries for achieving individual and collective self-reliance”. This transfer of technology, sharing expertise, and providing consulting services was not streamlined, but through what author and railwayman MA Rao calls “ad hoc arrangements of the Railway Board”.

A new trend

Increasing demands for railway assistance from India led to organizing the railways' consulting services through Government-owned enterprises, popularly known as Public Sector Undertakings (PSUs), under the control of the Ministry of Railways. The Rail India Technical and Economic Services (RITES) Limited and the Indian Railway Construction Company Ltd (IRCON), were created in 1974 and 1976, respectively. This heralded a new phase in the organizational structure of the Indian Railways. Canadian historian Ian J Kerr wrote in *Engines of Change*: “In a dramatic reversal of the dependence during the colonial period on foreign equipment and foreign experts India has become an exporter of railroad equipment and technical and managerial expertise”.